Bob Dylan and Joan Baez, emerged from the same kind of artistic desire for a music that was relevant, topical, and grew from indigenous roots.

Milanés and Puebla relied mostly on traditional Cuban musical forms. Rodríguez took experimentation with the traditional forms to its greatest heights, both musically and poetically. Some of his most moving songs explored the bounds of the personal and the political, with magical imagery, emotion, and political commentary fused into haunting melodies. Lost blue unicorns are found in the mountains of El Salvador, while children find the strength to face the future even without the Three Kings. “I was born to dream the sun, and to say things that awaken love,” he writes, in a song that evokes a nightmare of bombs and chaos.

Both Milanés and Rodríguez kept up their pace of creative production and political engagement into the 1990s. (Puebla died in 1989 after a long illness.) “How seductive questioning is,” Rodríguez wrote in “Disillusionment” in 1989. “Disillusionment – a brilliant fashion show. It opened a business, rediscovered leisure. Like tourism, it invented the abyss. It touched the diamond and turned it to coal.” Milanés, who is openly bisexual and in fact was imprisoned at the end of the 1960s, recorded “The Original Sin” in 1994, describing a love between two men. “We are not God,” he warned. “Let’s not get it wrong again,” referring to Cuba’s long-standing and various forms of discrimination against homosexuality.

In the 1990s there was a flowering of Cuban rap music, ranging from commercially oriented and fairly apolitical groups to more edgy, underground groups. “At first the state promoted commercially oriented rap as a way of diluting rap’s radical potential,” Fernandes explains, but soon it “turned to praising the underground groups for their rejection of commercialism.” In the latter position, Cuba’s government followed other leftist governments in Latin America that “build alliances with the hip-hop movement” in order to take advantage of “the role that hip-hop can play in engaging black youth.”[25]

One Cuban critic suggested that Cuba’s revolutionary context meant that Cuban rappers played an entirely different role in society than elsewhere because of “the emancipatory vision that these people share with the Cuban Revolution, its forms of struggle, its acts of resistance;